

Manchester City take control of title race with victory over Arsenal

Erling Haaland struck a vital winner as Manchester City slashed Arsenal's Premier League lead to three points with a 2-1 victory over the Gunners at the Etihad Stadium.

The Norwegian pounced after 65 minutes of a compelling clash on Sunday, sparing Gianluigi Donnarumma's blushes after the goalkeeper had gifted Kai Havertz an equaliser following Rayan Cherki's opener.

It was Arsenal's second successive defeat and City, with a game in hand, clearly have the momentum as they bid to overhaul the long-time leaders and claim a seventh title in nine years.

Arsenal, seeking their first league crown since 2004, still have the advantage of points on the board but the loss was undoubtedly a bitter blow.

City had come into the game with their tails up after capitalising on Arsenal's slip-up last week and their fans were expectant.

With last month's Carabao Cup final victory over the same opponents also still fresh in the memory, the atmosphere was buoyant and City responded.

They started strongly and Haaland almost forced David Raya into an early error before having a shot blocked.

City sounded a further warning as Cherki fired at goal and his effort ricocheted off the arm of Gabriel onto a post. The hosts appealed for a penalty but nothing was given.

Arsenal threatened themselves as Cristian Mosquera headed over from a corner but City took the lead with a brilliant goal from Cherki in the 16th minute.

The Frenchman was fed by Matheus Nunes after a Rodri cross was only half-cleared and weaved around two defenders before placing a shot into the bottom corner.

It was a stunning effort but, for City, the sublime was immediately followed by the ridiculous as, just two minutes later, Donnarumma dithered as the ball was sent back to him from a throw-in.

Havertz chased what seemed an unlikely cause and was rewarded as Donnarumma's clearance cannoned off his foot into the net.

It was the German's first league goal since scoring against City in February 2025 but the visitors could not build on it.

Haaland missed the target and Marc Guehi headed at Raya before Antoine Semenyo went close.

Haaland hit the outside of a post early in the second half but Arsenal did begin to step up approaching the hour.

A slick move led to Martin Odegaard playing Havertz through on goal but Donnarumma atoned for his earlier error as he raced off his line to block. City had another let-off as Eberechi Eze curled against a post.

The game swung from end to end and City reclaimed the lead as they attacked down the left and Nico O'Reilly's cross was helped on by Rodri and Haaland swivelled inside the area to score.

Arsenal rallied and Gabriel thumped a header against the base of the post from a free-kick.

Tempers began to fray late on and Gabriel was fortunate to escape with a booking after pushing his head towards Haaland in a flare-up of an old rivalry.

Havertz went close to a stoppage-time equaliser but his header flew over and City held on.